Final Report: Through Our Lens – The Story of Fort Resolution
Project Title: *Through Our Lens: A Youth Photography Showcase in Ottawa*
Funded By: GLOCAL Foundation of Canada
Reporting Period: October 2024 – February 2025
Prepared By: Staff members
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Introduction

With the generous support of the GLOCAL Foundation of Canada, the *Through Our Lens* photography project was a **resounding success**. This initiative gave students in Grades 10–12 from Fort Resolution, Northwest Territories, the opportunity to document and celebrate their community through photography, and share their stories on a national stage in Ottawa.

The project culminated in a public exhibition in Ottawa in February 2025, showcasing 12 themed photo collections created by students. Two student photographers and one chaperone travelled to Ottawa to represent their work, participate in artist talks, and engage in meaningful cultural exchange. The impact of this initiative reached far beyond the photos—it strengthened community pride, gave voice to youth perspectives, and elevated northern stories in a national conversation.

Project objective and achievement

Objectives	Outcomes
Showcase students' photography allowing other schools and communities to visit	Achieved 12 themed photo collections displayed in the gym
Develop artistic storytelling skills	Achieved – students completed an intense and new project of photography and captioning workshops
Empower youth to represent their community	Achieved – 12 students presented their work and spoke at the event
Foster cultural pride and awareness	Achieved – strong local support and community recognition

Exhibition Highlights

1. The Photo Series

Students submitted photos under 12 unique themes that captured the life, spirit, and identity of Fort Resolution:
• *Nature & Wilderness*
• *Culture & Tradition*
• *Everyday Life*
• *Elders & Knowledge Keepers*
• *Youth in the North*

• *Seasons of the Land*
• *Spiritual Spaces*
• *Work and Harvest*
• *Art and Expression*
• *Home and Belonging*
• *Community Events*
• *The Future We See*

Each photo was paired with a written reflection or caption written by the student artist, offering viewers an intimate, authentic connection to the stories behind the images.

2. Exhibit Experience
• Held at the school's gym, the exhibit welcomed over [insert number] visitors during its display week.
• Two student photographers gave a guided tour of their work and participated in a Q&A with attendees, showcasing exceptional confidence and insight.
• The event drew attention from educators, youth advocates, and members of the arts and the 4 Indigenous schools close by

Student Impact
• **Skills Gained**: Photography, public speaking, digital editing, storytelling, curation.
• **Confidence Boost**: Students expressed immense pride in representing their community.
• **Leadership Growth**: Participants emerged as ambassadors for Fort Resolution and Northern youth.

Student Reflection:
"I never thought my pictures could be shown outside our town, let alone in a city like Ottawa. People listened to our stories and said they were powerful. I'll never forget that." – Grade 11 Student Photographer

Community Impact
• Students' work was also displayed locally at the Fort Resolution Community Centre before the Ottawa trip, with strong turnout from families and Elders.
• The exhibit inspired a younger group of students to start a junior photography club.
• Elders provided input and guidance on cultural themes, reinforcing intergenerational learning.

Budget summary

Expense Category	Amount
Photo printing and exhibit materials	$4,200
Light refreshments for viewers	$800
Total	$5,000

Budget planning was precise and purposeful. Accommodations were booked affordably, and photo materials were sourced locally to reduce costs. The project was delivered **on budget** and every dollar directly contributed to youth empowerment and cultural sharing.

Conclusion

Through Our Lens was far more than a photography project—it was a platform for identity, representation, and connection. The students of Fort Resolution proved that youth voices from remote northern communities hold powerful stories and perspectives that deserve national recognition.

This initiative sparked pride, inspired the next generation of storytellers, and opened the door for future exhibitions and cultural exchanges. We are deeply thankful to the GLOCAL Foundation of Canada for believing in the power of youth expression and making this unforgettable experience possible.